the department of pharmaceuticals). A Rajya Sabha MP, Mandaviya had been on the core COVID-19 response team for over a year, and replaced Dr Harshavardhan.[40]

Second, Modi purged the entire government in his home state of Gujarat in September 2021. The Vijay Rupani-led state government had been particularly criticised for its response to the pandemic and, after he quit as state chief minister, the BJP replaced his entire erstwhile council of twenty-two ministers. In came twenty-four fresh ministers, who took office under the new chief minister, Bhupendra Patel, himself a first-time MLA.[41] Replacing the old with the new is an old but under-appreciated Modi strategy that had helped him retain power in Gujarat earlier too. The BJP had replaced a significant number of its sitting legislators in the Gujarat assembly elections in 2002, 2007, 2012 and 2017 as a tactic to beat anti-incumbency sentiments. The gambit worked each time—with the party attaining high strike rates in such constituencies.[42] Whether it will work this time too depends a great deal on the performance of the incoming leaders who have a little over a year to perform, with polls due in the state in December 2022.

Similarly, in Uttar Pradesh too, where there had been public rumblings within the state BJP itself on the handling of the pandemic,[43] Yogi Adityanath revamped his government by inducting seven new ministers to consolidate the BJP's rainbow caste coalition of Savarn, non-Yadav OBC and non-Jatav Dalits ahead of the assembly polls in 2022. The social profile of the new ministers he inducted into the state government in September 2021 (three OBCs, two SCs, one ST and one Brahmin) was tellingly 'the same as the seven inducted in the Modi ministry from the state just two months ago.'[44]

Finally, at the national level, the Modi government recalibrated and focused intensely on vaccinations after the second wave.[45] By early-November 2021, over 53 per cent of Indians had received at least one dose of vaccinations, and over 23 per cent had been fully vaccinated.[46] This meant a cumulative vaccine coverage of 107.6 crore doses.[47] Globally, this meant that only China had vaccinated more people (228.5 crore doses) in comparison. India's vaccine